

Opera Mini has added a superb feature: a mouse! You can control it's movements by using the '2', '4', '6', and '8' keys for directional input. As you move around, different elements of the page get highlighted in a red box. Hit the joystick or the '5' key to zoom in. It's an incredibly efficient way of navigating pages.

Of course, if you have a touch-sensitive screen, you can easily navigate by using the stylus and tapping the screen at a certain box to zoom in. A lot of iPhone users think that Safari beats Opera Mini hands down. Well, the former takes 10MB of memory while the latter takes about 150KB; and let's not even get into who can render customised pages faster.

After zooming in, Opera continues to be efficient by fitting the page to width, thus requiring only uni-directional scrolling. If you wish to rotate the screen and view it in landscape mode, a quick press of '*' followed by '#' will take you through.

While touchscreen phones are becoming all the rage, keypad-based phones are where Opera's core strength lies. It's hard to keep track of the browser's numerous built-in shortcuts – and some plug-ins will even increase these manifold.

The built-in RSS reader serves basic purposes; but really, there are far better RSS readers available for cell phones and we will introduce you to one shortly.

And then there's the ability to sync up with your MyOpera account, letting you transfer bookmarks and notes from your desktop PC's Opera to your Opera Mini. Nice!

However, it's not all perfect. The biggest folly is its horrible rendering of YouTube. It's not that Opera can't open the videos, it's just that it's a messy, clunky experience (full-screen viewing, in particular, is an absolute nightmare). The Oslo-based company has issued patch after patch to try and rectify this, but it's nowhere near good enough. Still, we have other tools to serve that purpose, so this one slight is forgivable.

Overall, there is not a single mobile browser that can challenge Opera Mini. SkyFire is a good alternative if you're hell-bent on not installing Opera, and Mozilla's Fennec is still at an incumbent stage to stage any rivalry.

Final verdict? If your phone doesn't have Opera Mini installed, you need to do some serious introspection.

Platforms: Java

Price: Free